

❸ THE COROMANDEL CHALLENGE

The Coromandel coastline on India's east has so far eluded the BJP. The four main states here—West Bengal, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu—are run by regional satraps whom the BJP finds difficult to dislodge. Of their 127 seats, the BJP won just 26 in 2019, and 18 of them were from West Bengal's 42 seats. Here, the BJP's relentless drive to make inroads had paid off, helping it secure 41 per cent of the vote share for the first time, just two percentage points lower than Mamata Banerjee's Trinamool Congress (TMC), which won 26 seats. The TMC, however, recovered spectacularly in the 2021 assembly election, when it won a massive 215 out of the 294 seats with a 48 per cent vote share, leaving the BJP with 77 seats and 38 per cent of the votes.

What the BJP did earn undeniably was the place as the state's principal Opposition party, overtaking the Congress and Left parties. Hoping to better its tally this time, it has been hammering hard at Mamata Banerjee's leadership, alleging widespread corruption and making capital out of the allegations of land grab and sexual abuse against TMC leaders in Sandeshkhali, something that is expected to dent the TMC's women vote. The BJP has in fact fielded one of the victims and whistleblower, Rekha Patra, from Basirhat, where Sandeshkhali falls. The BJP also passed the rules governing the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) days before the Election Commission's Code of Conduct kicked in. The party is hoping to win the votes of the sizeable Matua community, who are Dalit Hindu refugees from Bangladesh for whom citizenship has both symbolic and practical value. However, with the CAA excluding Muslim refugees, the BJP's ploy may boomerang as it may consolidate the significant 27 per cent Muslim vote in favour of the TMC. The saffron side's only hope is that the breakdown of the seat-sharing talks with I.N.D.I.A. hurts Mamata's chances, especially because it may split the Muslim vote.

In Andhra Pradesh, which has 25 seats, the return of N. Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party (TDP) to the NDA fold is likely to boost its tally, especially with actor Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena also joining forces. With assembly polls being held simultaneously with the Lok Sabha election here, the NDA hopes to cash in on the anti-incumbency against the Jagan Reddy-led YSRCP (Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party) government. The plan is to bag more Lok Sabha seats than the three the TDP won last time and win a majority of the assembly seats to form a government in the state. However, the saffron side's plans to secure neighbouring Odisha, where too assembly polls will be held simultaneously, came a cropper as an alliance with the ruling Biju Janata Dal (BJD), led by its redoubtable chief minister Naveen Patnaik, did not materialise. The BJP had made inroads into Odisha with eight out of the state's 21 parliamentary seats in 2019 but was trounced in the assembly polls when Patnaik's BJD won 112 out of the 147 seats and the BJP a mere 23. The talks failed over the BJP's insistence on joining the state government if the alliance won a majority, which Patnaik was against. He also didn't concede to the BJP's demand for the Puri, Bhubaneswar and Kendrapara seats.

In Tamil Nadu, where the BJP has

MODI HAS CONVERTED THE ELECTION INTO A US-STYLE PRESIDENTIAL CONTEST, GETTING VOTERS TO COMPARE HIS TRACK RECORD WITH THAT OF PRIME CHALLENGER RAHUL GANDHI, WHO HAS NEVER RUN A GOVERNMENT